



MARCH 8, 2026

Our community is home to vastly different languages, traditions, and histories. Yet within the heritage of each culture lies a bond that unites us all: the strength and influence of women.

International Women's Day, celebrated annually on March 8, is a global occasion dedicated to recognizing the social, economic, cultural, and political achievements of women. At the same time, it is a time to reflect on the progress made and the inequalities that still persist. It should not be seen as a practice to be celebrated only one day a year; rather, it should be an opportunity to raise awareness and reaffirm the importance of gender equality and not forget all the injustices women have experienced throughout history.

Women's Day, however, should not only be a celebration of achievements, but also a reminder.

Let us begin from the premise that in recent history, women lacked access to education, the right to vote, and even the ability to choose their fundamental rights. Who knows how many talents have been hidden simply because these individuals were women? How many potential scientists, economists, or lawyers have been denied their opportunities simply because of this? Even when these paths were explored, how often were their merits not fully recognized? A clear example can be found in the story of Rosalind Franklin. Despite her crucial role in the discovery of the structure of DNA, we often hear only about Watson and Crick, to the point that she wasn't even mentioned when they received the Nobel Prize for their discovery—even though this would not have been possible without her contribution.

Indeed, we have evolved as a society, yet women still face intense social pressure. Every day, especially on social media, we are complicit in social phenomena like body shaming, as if the social expectations placed on women are often higher and more contradictory. If you're too thin, you're described as "skinny"; if you're overweight, you're accused of lacking self-control. At the same time, even if you meet conventional beauty standards, you're told you do it to attract male attention. If you're introverted and have few

friends, you're considered modest; if you're outgoing and extroverted, you risk being labeled negatively. Slut-shaming, especially in societies we call "developed," has reached such levels that many women are afraid to socialize freely for fear of being judged.

This social disparity can also be found in the scientific field, a clear example of which is the study of many conditions closely linked to women's health. Endometriosis, which affects approximately 190 million women worldwide, has been significantly less studied, according to available data, than conditions like male pattern baldness.

In the first quarter of 2026, seven victims of femicide have already been recorded in Italy alone. Globally, recent estimates indicate that tens of thousands of women are killed each year by male partners or family members—approximately 50,000 in 2024. Why are these data important? Because femicide is not just a tragedy; this phenomenon highlights how, culturally, some men still perceive women as property to be controlled, rather than as equals.

As far as wage differences are concerned, there are still significant inequalities today: on average, women still face a 17-23% pay gap compared to men and in Italy according to INPS data and the most recent analyses, female workers earn on average around 20% less than their male colleagues, with the difference reaching higher peaks in some sectors, despite their skills, knowledge, and performance being no less.

So, on International Women's Day, you can give flowers and post online. But first, show respect—not to women as women, but to women as equals. We cannot call ourselves a truly developed society if people continue to be treated differently simply because of their gender. Remember that, despite history sometimes teaching us otherwise, women, equally with men, have built the foundations of our society, and as British writer Virginia Woolf said, "Behind every great man, there is always a great woman."

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